

The Writing Center at
Purdue University Calumet presents

Prewriting Techniques

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The bottom of the slide features decorative wavy lines. A thick, dark gold band curves across the bottom, with a thinner, lighter gold band curving above it, creating a layered, wave-like effect.

What is Prewriting?

- ▶ Prewriting is any activity that a writer uses to prepare for writing

Why is it Important?

- ▶ Prewriting helps you:
 - Organize your thoughts
 - Begin your research
 - Explore ideas that might have otherwise been undiscovered

When do you Prewrite?

- ▶ Prewriting is most useful as the first step of the writing process.
- ▶ However, it can be used any time you are “stuck” in order to come up with new ideas

Types of Prewriting

► Writing

- Brainstorming
- Free Write
- Lists
- Questions
- Timeline

► Visual

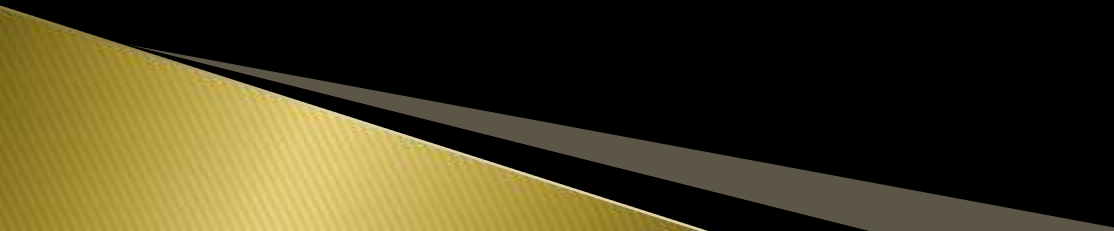
- Webs/Branching
- Maps

► Verbal

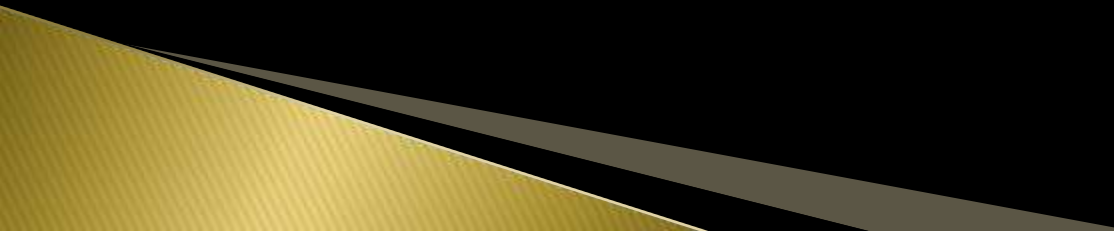
- Bounce Board

Writing

Brainstorming

- ▶ Begin with a blank piece of paper
 - ▶ Write your topic at the top
 - ▶ Write down everything you can about the topic
 - ▶ Write anything; don't worry about how crazy your ideas are, grammar, or editing.
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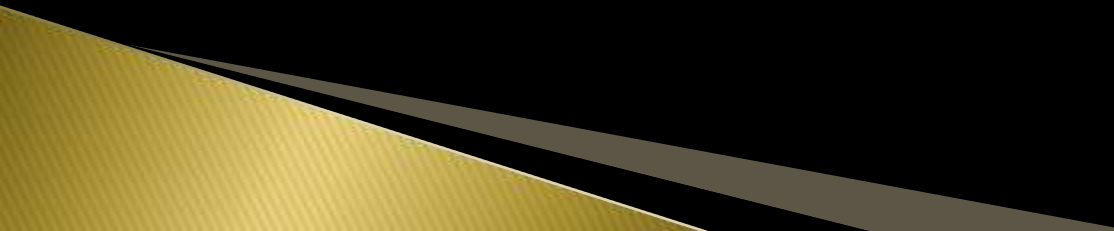
Brainstorming (cont.)

- ▶ Look at your list and reconsider your topic
 - ▶ Eliminate any ideas that don't relate to your topic
 - ▶ Organize your remaining points
 - Group similar ideas
 - Try to arrange ideas in a logical order to use in your essay
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Brainstorming (cont.)

- ▶ Useful when – trying to think of main points for your paper or trying to outline your ideas
- ▶ Example:
 - Topic – Smoking on Campus
 - Mess from cigarette buds
 - Second hand smoke
 - Bad smell
 - Anti-smoking groups
 - Health effects

Free Writing

- ▶ Sit down and write whatever is on your mind
 - ▶ Give yourself a time limit
 - ▶ DO NOT erase anything
 - ▶ Never stop writing, just write something
 - ▶ Remember that no idea is a bad idea when freewriting
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Free Writing (cont.)

- ▶ If you need to, use a prompt or question to begin free writing
 - Ex: Write for 15 minutes using the following phrase as your first line...

“The stain will not come out...”

- ▶ Useful when – starting a writing assignment, thinking of a topic, or sorting through thoughts

Lists

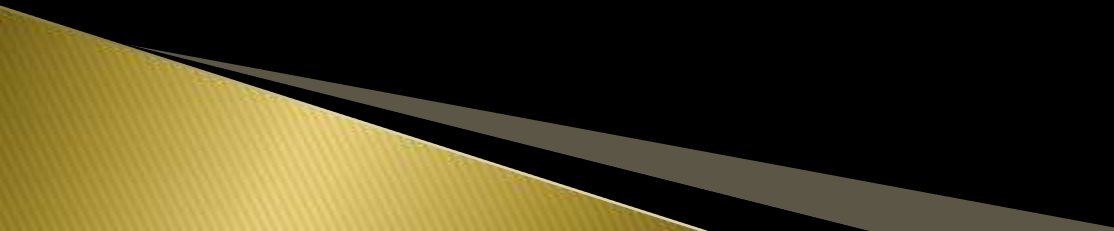
- ▶ Lists are similar to brainstorming but involve grouping your ideas as you write
- ▶ First write down main ideas you have for your paper
- ▶ List related ideas or items under each main idea
- ▶ Create new main ideas as need
 - You may need to do this if some of your smaller ideas don't fit under an existing category or you don't have enough ideas for your paper

Lists (cont.)

- ▶ Useful when – trying to think of main ideas or points for your paper

- ▶ Example:
 - Topic – Tablets in the Classroom
 - Benefits
 - Digital books can be cheaper
 - Students develop tech skills
 - Negative Effects
 - They are a distraction
 - Tablets can be expensive

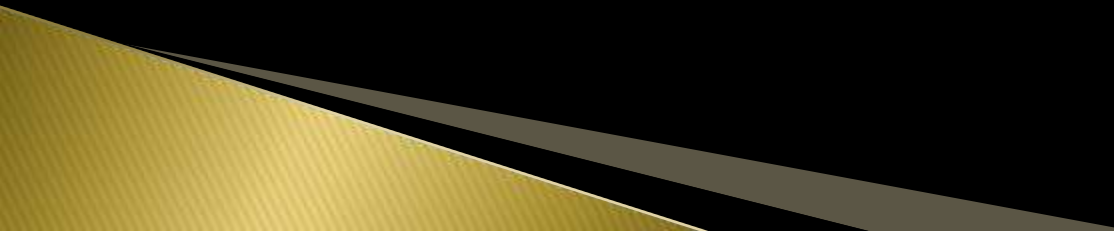
Questions

- ▶ Begin by writing down any questions you may have about your topic or the prompt
 - ▶ Write any questions down that you think of as you write
 - ▶ Questions should involve who, what, when, where, and why as well as personal questions, like how you can relate to the topic
 - ▶ Once you are all “questioned” out, begin researching any questions that stand out to you
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Questions (cont.)

- ▶ Some questions may lead to others, so don't be afraid to write them down while you are researching
- ▶ Useful when – creating a thesis or developing a stand for a paper

Timeline

- ▶ Make a three column chart
 1. Year
 2. Events that took place that year
 3. The emotions that were present at the time
 - ▶ Fill in the different years, events, and emotions as they relate to your topic
 - ▶ Try to be as detailed as possible when writing your information
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Timeline

- Useful when – writing about a specific time or writing an autobiographical piece

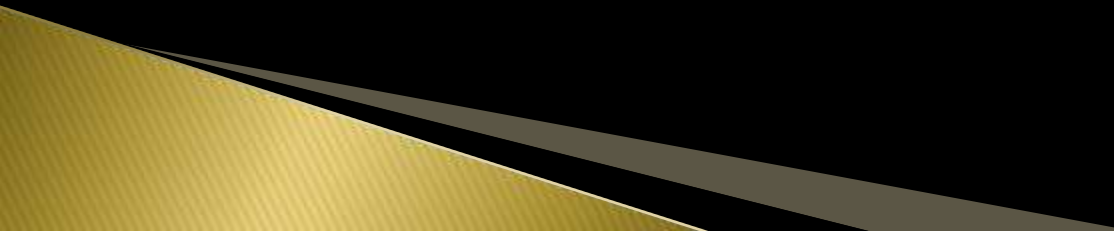
Year	Event	Emotion
1995	Start kindergarden	Scared of bullies
2006	Graduate 8th grade	Happy, but sad that some friends are going to different high schools

Visual

Webs / Branching

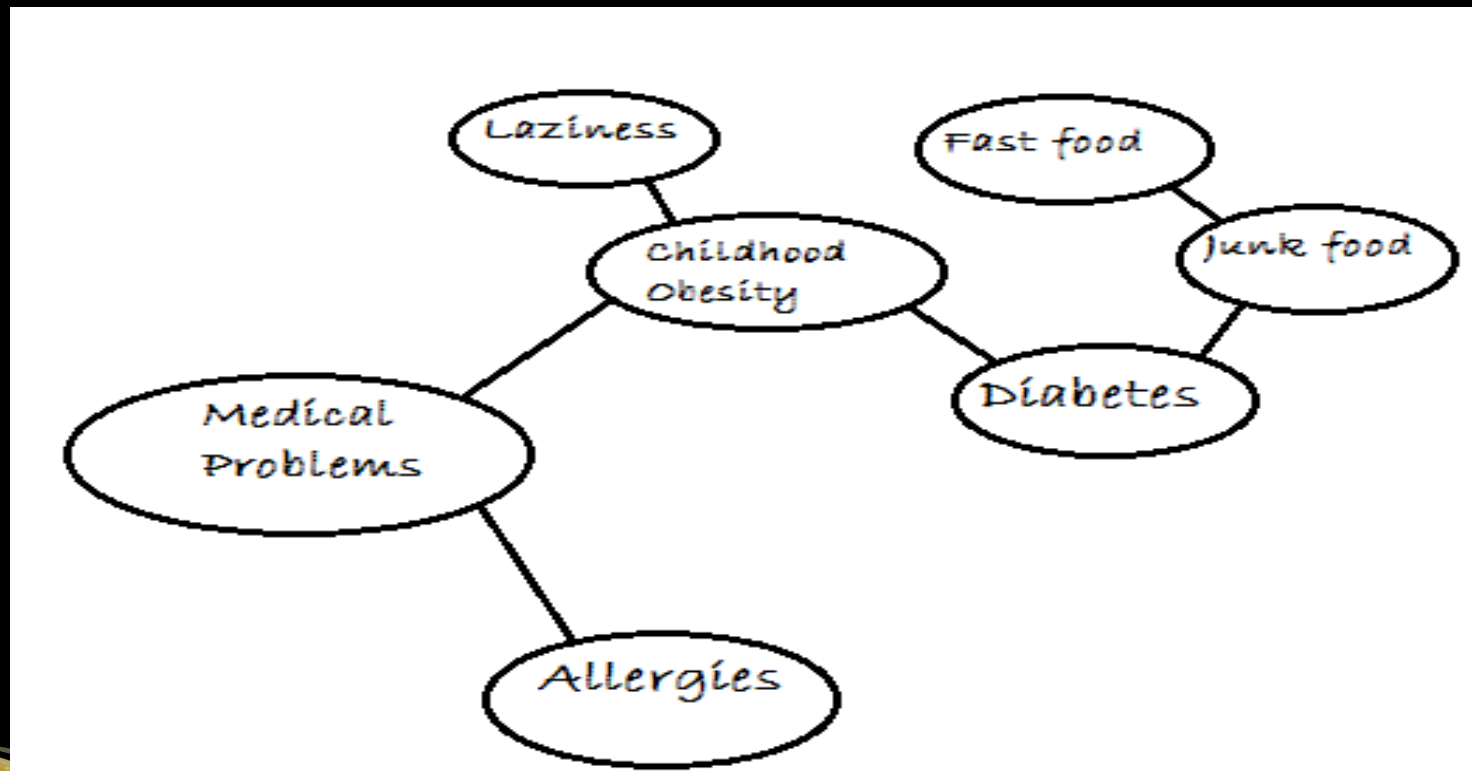
- ▶ This is a type of prewriting that allows you to explore several ideas as you think of them.
- ▶ You can create these even when your ideas aren't clear.

Webs / Branching (cont.)

- ▶ Pick a broad topic and write it down in the center of a paper.
 - ▶ Circle the word then write words that you think of as you consider your topic
 - ▶ Write down any words you associate with your topic; write quickly
 - ▶ Circle each word and group them around your central topic
 - ▶ Connect new words to previous words
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Webs/Branching (cont.)

- Useful when – trying to pick a topic of making a topic more specific



Maps

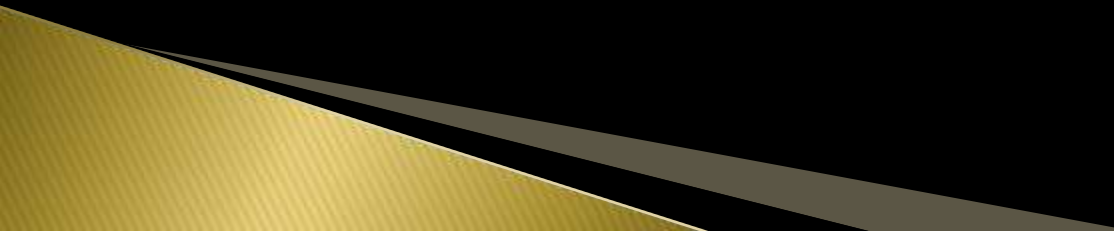
- ▶ Draw a place out and make where important events happened
- ▶ Only draw for a short time
- ▶ Useful when – writing about a place or writing an autobiographical piece

Maps (cont.)



Verbal

Bounce Board

- ▶ Find someone to work with
 - ▶ Tell them about the topic you are writing about
 - ▶ Share your ideas
 - ▶ Ask them any questions you may have
 - ▶ Encourage them to ask questions too
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Bounce Board (cont.)

- ▶ This works best if you develop a conversation about your ideas, sharing new ideas and questions.
- ▶ Useful when – trying to think of different ideas to include in your paper or possible research questions

Outlining Your Paper

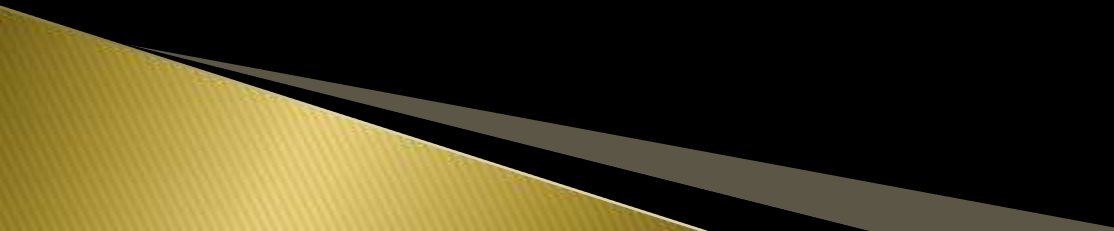
Creating an Outline

- ▶ Once you have your topic, main ideas, and supporting ideas, you can use them to create an outline
- ▶ Outlining your paper before writing can help you make sure your paper has a clear structure and organization

Creating an Outline (cont.)

- ▶ Consider these things:
 - What is the purpose of your paper?
 - Who is your audience?
 - What is your thesis?

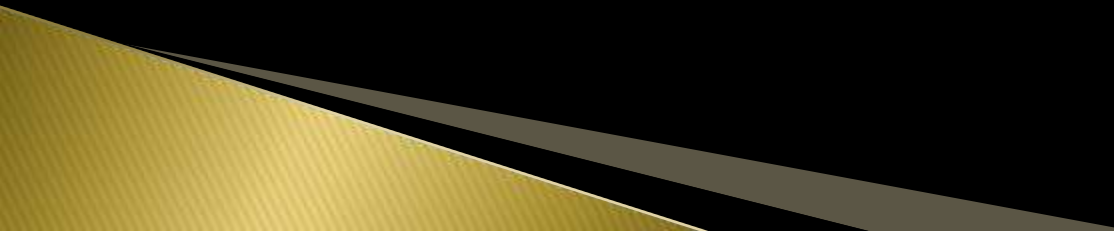
Creating an Outline (cont.)

- ▶ List all of your ideas that you want to include in your paper
 - ▶ Group them into related categories
 - ▶ Arrange the information in a logical order (i.e. general to specific)
 - ▶ Create and label main and sub headings.
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Elements to Include

- ▶ Make sure your outline has:
 - A thesis
 - Main ideas supporting your thesis
 - Supporting ideas for each main idea
 - Any details or examples you will include in your paper

Benefits

- ▶ Helps clarify your ideas before beginning writing
 - ▶ Helps organize your ideas
 - ▶ Presents ideas logically and clearly
 - ▶ Shows a relationship between ideas
 - ▶ Creates a clear overall structure
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Conclusion

- ▶ These are just some of the different prewriting techniques out there
 - ▶ Trying just one can help you come up with a topic or ideas before writing your paper
 - ▶ Make sure to try different techniques to see which you like best
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Thanks and Good Luck!